

Chalo Dilli!

Our Circulation team undertakes a tour of the North to locate new distributors

Some of our readers complain that they do not get Digit from the news-stands in their town. Taking up the challenge of ensuring that readers in small to middle level cities do not have to travel far to get their copy of Digit, our Circulation and Logistics team travelled 27 cities in the North of India to hire new distributors and courier services.

January 2002: The team was flagged off from Mumbai. Suitably armed to brave near Zero degree temperatures, the five

Himachal Pradesh—a route packed with hairpin bends. There were no hotels and few vehicles along this unfrequented stretch, but they made it to Dehra Dun in 5 hours flat. This gave them time to enjoy a good night's rest.

Day 9 was quite uneventful, but while leaving Roorkee the

there. To catch up with their schedule they rested briefly before leaving for the next destination—Delhi. Heavy winter fog impeded visibility, but they wouldn't stop for anything, except food at about 2.30 am. In fact, soon



The team with the drive: (L to R) Arup, Nikhil, Sourav and Akhilesh



were on the road from 7 am till 2 at night. The team would spend two to three hours in each city, finish work, and move on to the next destination. The first week was smooth sailing, except for the fact that most *dhabs* in the North do not serve rice as part of standard meal. Our guys from the rice belt carried their own supplies of rice and dal and for Rs 50, they would convince *dhaba*-owners along the way to allow them an hour of cooking time and have piping hot self-made meals!

Their misadventures began after the team touched Simla. It was day 8 and the team finished their work by 7 pm. Dehra Dun was the next destination. The road map showed that the only way to Dehra Dun was through Panchkula (Chandigarh). But eager to reach the next destination as soon as possible, the team relied on their own sense of direction and discovered a new 'shortcut' to Dehra Dun via Nahan and Paonta Sahib in

Sumo had diesel only enough for around 60 km. The next stop was Saharanpur, about 70 km away, and the adventurers decided to try their luck and refuel along the way. But they ran out of diesel just 17 km down the highway, and with no petrol pump in sight. Luckily, they spotted a tractor coming their way—Akhilesh, the head of the team, jumped off the Sumo, caught up with the tractor, and asked for

help. They were towed to the nearest petrol pump in the dark of the night through a lonely track in the midst of eerie silent woods. It was a silent and scary ride and upon reaching the petrol pump, they learnt that the track they had just covered was a shortcut to Saharanpur and that it was a dacoit infested area.

The team touched Saharanpur at midnight, and it was too late to do any work

other vehicles followed their lead and a convoy of vehicles followed them to Delhi, where they reached at 5.30 am.

After a full day spent wrapping up their work, the team was eager to head home to Mumbai. The aim was to leave early next morning and drive straight to Mumbai, to reach there within 24 hours, with stopovers at Agra and Gwalior for further deals with distributors. A massive traffic jam ahead of Mhow in Madhya Pradesh and the several police check posts between Sirpur and Sindhwa, ahead of Mhow added hours to their tight timing. This stretch is prone to highway robberies and the police allow vehicles to pass through only in batches of 10. Our veteran roadsters, keen to get home, overtook the truckers traveling at a slow 40 kmph, joined another cavalcade of trucks at the next check post. They touched home in 27 hours. ■

TARGET ACHIEVED: 11 new distributors

AVERAGE SPEED THROUGH THE JOURNEY: 100 kmph (Arup is an ex-rally driver)

TOTAL EXPENSE: An unbelievable Rs 20,000 (including diesel cost)